India's efforts to reach out to China, and its early engagement with the Nixon administration. The next section covers the ambivalent Chinese response to the Indian overtures. Beijing's more positive reaction to American efforts is then discussed, as is the impact on US-Pakistan relations. The subsequent section covers how these dynamics and Sino-Soviet hostility affected the 1971 war, as well as US-India relations that year. The last section considers the impact of the crisis and Sino-US rapprochement in 1972, when Delhi and Washington disengaged with each other in a number of ways.

Reaching for Rapprochements (1969)

The year 1969 featured overtures to China by the US and India. One outreach, that of the US, is better known than the other, but both would lay the groundwork for transformations in relations with China for the US and India over the next few decades.

US Views of China and India

In a speech in 1966, President Johnson had laid out the possibility of a different Sino-US relationship—one characterized by engagement—and an Asia where communist and noncommunist states co-existed peacefully. A year later, in *Foreign Affairs*, then presidential candidate Nixon had outlined his interest in exploring engagement with China. In 1968, outgoing national security adviser Walt Rostow had noted to Kissinger that one of the "objectives … within [the new administration's] grasp" was the "beginnings of normalizing our relations with Communist China."[5] And once in office, Nixon demanded of Kissinger, "How do we establish relations with China?"[6]

China was not just important for its own sake but also because of the Nixon administration's other two priorities: the Soviet Union and Vietnam. At a time when US dominance and its strategic and economic superiority were under threat, Nixon and Kissinger directed their foreign policy efforts toward maintaining America's global standing. Based on Vietnam-era geopolitical and domestic realities, and the belief that a balance of power would produce global stability, Nixon's foreign policy came to revolve around what was called triangular diplomacy—the "calculated management